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Social Learning, Peer Influence, and Social Norms

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Background: Social learning, observational learning, and social information

Social learning means learning from other people or other animals, rather than only from your own trial and error. It includes watching, copying, being taught, and using social information from others' actions, words, and products. (17 sources)

Social learning is usually defined in broad terms as learning that is shaped by observing or interacting with another individual, or with the products of their behavior, instead of learning alone through direct personal experience. This broad definition is widely used across psychology, behavioral ecology, and cultural evolution, even though fields differ in emphasis. (Hewlett, 2016) (Boekholt et al., 2021) (Dahl et al., 2024) (Kendal et al., 2018)

As an umbrella term, social learning covers many ways that others shape learning and decision making. It can include imitation, observational learning of new skills, parental and peer effects on preferences, teaching, advice, and other informal forms of shared learning in groups and cultures. (Gariepy et al., 2014) (Slater et al., 2020) (Felice et al., 2022) (Dahl et al., 2024)

A useful narrower term is observational learning, which refers to learning by attending to what others do or say. In this sense, observational learning is one important type of social learning: people can acquire new behaviors, skills, and expectations by watching others act, without having to perform the behavior first themselves. This is one reason social learning can save the costs and risks of individual trial-and-error learning. (Stibe et al., 2019) (Felice et al., 2022) (Nazir et al., 2026) (Ramsey et al., 2021)

The literature also distinguishes among forms of observational social learning. Imitation means copying another's actions, often at the level of visible behavior, while emulation means learning about the structure of the task, the environment, or the result of an action and then reproducing that outcome, not necessarily the exact movements. Other basic processes, such as social facilitation and local enhancement, also let the behavior of others guide attention and action. (Tran et al., 2021) (Tennie et al., 2010) (Danwitz et al., 2025) (Lewis et al., 2020) (Lind et al., 2018)

More broadly, the key input in all of these cases is social information: information carried by others' actions, signals, language, and artifacts. That information can move through vertical pathways from parents to offspring, oblique pathways from older non-parents to younger individuals, or horizontal pathways among peers. High-fidelity forms such as imitation, emulation, and teaching are especially important when a group needs to pass on complex skills reliably. (Boekholt et al., 2021) (Stibe et al., 2019) (Kukofka et al., 2024)

Overall, a notable theme in this literature is that learning from others is not a single mechanism but a family of processes through which thoughts, actions, values, and skills spread across individuals and groups.

People and other animals do not just learn from direct rewards and mistakes; they also learn from the social world around them. (Kendal et al., 2018) (Gariepy et al., 2014) (Zhang et al., 2025) (Nazir et al., 2026)

Evidence

(Hewlett, 2016)

Social Learning and Innovation in Hunter-Gatherers

> *"Social learning is basically acquiring skills or knowledge from others rather than learning them on your own. (Heyes, 1994) defines it as "learning that is influenced by observation, or interaction with, another animal (typically conspecific) or its products.""*

(Boekholt et al., 2021)

Organized to learn: the influence of social structure on social learning opportunities in a group

> *"Social learning, defined as "learning that is influenced by observation of, or interaction with, another animal or its product" (Heyes, 1994)"*

> *"Social transmission of knowledge can occur in different pathways: the most common one is vertical social transmission (i.e., parent to offspring), but it can also be oblique (i.e., adult to unrelated juvenile) or horizontal (i.e., between peers of the same generation)."*

(Dahl et al., 2024)

Wanting to matter and learning to care: A neurodevelopmental window of opportunity for (Pro) social learning?

> *"Social learning encompasses a wide range of types of learning and is often defined differently across disciplines and fields. One common and inclusive definition entails all 'learning that is facilitated by observation of, or interaction with, another individual (or its products)' (Kendal et al., 2018). In psychology and behavioral ecology there has been a strong emphasis on skill learning through imitation behavior. However, a great deal of social learning involves advice taking and giving, teaching, and trial-and-error learning experiences while interacting with others"*

> *".To accommodate social learning, basic reinforcement models are often extended with parameters to accommodate the informational (e.g. update belief about outcomes) and normative (e.g. positive experience of choosing the majority action) processes in social learning (Biele et al., 2009)."*

(Kendal et al., 2018)

Social Learning Strategies: Bridge-Building between Fields.

> *"Learning that is facilitated by observation of, or interaction with, another individual or its products, is known as 'social learning' (see Glossary) (Heyes, 1994)[2]"*

> *".Instead, heuristics, or "social learning strategies" (SLSs) (also termed "transmission biases"), are expected to bias individuals to copy particular behaviours ("what" strategies), performed by specific others ("who" strategies), under suitable circumstances ("when" strategies) [5](Laland, 2004)."*

(Gariepy et al., 2014)

Social learning in humans and other animals

> *"Decisions made by individuals can be influenced by what others think and do. Social learning includes a wide array of behaviors such as imitation, observational learning of novel foraging techniques, peer or parental influences on individual preferences, as well as outright teaching."*

(Slater et al., 2020)

Social Learning and Transdisciplinary Co-Production: A Social Practice Approach

> *"It includes interpersonal settings though which individuals informally and collaboratively learn from one another as well as the culture in which they live and the groups with which they interact [31]."*

(Felice et al., 2022)

Learning from others is good, with others is better: the role of social interaction in human acquisition of new knowledge

> *"When such learning occurs via transmission of information across members of a social group, it is defined as 'social learning' [17].Importantly, there are many ways in which learning can be social, depending on the role that the social agent(s) has in the learning process of a given individual.Therefore, the term social learning is a broad term that refers to any form of learning-such as motor, verbal and knowledge-based learning-via any form of social context, including observation of others (Cross, 2012)(Cross*

et al., 2008), imitation (Blair, 1993) and interactive learning (figure 1).

Observational learning refers to learning via attending to someone else's actions and/or listening to them delivering information.Imitation refers to copying someone else (Blair, 1993)."

(Stibe et al., 2019)

Social Influence Scale for Technology Design and Transformation

"Within a social context, people learn from others by observing their behaviors [3]. This implies that the transmission of information from one individual to another happens through imitation, teaching, and spoken or written language. According to Bandura [3], social learning is ubiquitous and potent because it allows people to avoid the costs of individual learning. Essentially, social learning is about learning new behaviors by watching others perform them."

(Nazir et al., 2026)

A Neurocomputational Model of Observation-Based Decision Making with a Focus on Trust

"While an individual's own experiences may be the primary reason behind his/her learning, learning from others, i.e., social learning, also plays an important role (Campbell-Meiklejohn et al., 2010). According to Bandura [10], social learning is based on observation, imitation, and cognitive modeling. In this context, individual learning by observing the behavior of others is known as observational learning (Ramsey et al., 2021)."

(Ramsey et al., 2021)

Watch and Learn: The Cognitive Neuroscience of Learning from Others' Actions.

"The mirror neuron system has dominated understanding of observational learning from a cognitive neuroscience perspective. Our review highlights the value of observational learning frameworks that integrate a more diverse and distributed set of cognitive and brain systems, including those implicated in sensorimotor transformations, as well as in more general processes such as executive control, reward, and social cognition. We argue that understanding how observational learning occurs in the real world will require neuroscientific frameworks that consider how visuomotor processes interface with more general aspects of cognition, as well as how learning context and action complexity shape mechanisms supporting learning from watching others."

(Tran et al., 2021)

One Function One Tool? A Review on Mutual Exclusivity in Tool Use Learning in Human and Non-human Species

"social learning, which is defined as the ability to acquire new skills from observation or interaction with other individuals (Heyes, 1994)(Galef et al., 2005)"

"social learning research predominantly has focused on the forms of learning from conspecifics and observable other agents; among the different existing forms, we can find imitation, defined as copying others' actions (Whiten et al., 2009), see also (Whiten, 1998)(Horner et al., 2005)(Buttelmann et al., 2013) or emulation, defined as a form of learning about the environment or an action's results (Whiten et al., 2009), see also (Horner et al., 2005)(Hopper et al., 2008)(Tennie et al., 2010)."

(Tennie et al., 2010)

Evidence for Emulation in Chimpanzees in Social Settings Using the Floating Peanut Task

"Background It is still unclear which observational learning mechanisms underlie the transmission of difficult problem-solving skills in chimpanzees. In particular, two different mechanisms have been proposed: imitation and emulation. Previous studies have largely failed to control for social factors when these mechanisms were targeted. Methods In an attempt to resolve the existing discrepancies, we adopted the 'floating peanut task', in which subjects need to spit water into a tube until it is sufficiently full for floating peanuts to be grasped. In a previous study only a few chimpanzees were able to invent the necessary solution (and they either did so in their first trials or never). Here we compared success levels in baseline tests with two experimental conditions that followed: 1) A full model condition to test whether social demonstrations would be effective, and 2) A social emulation control condition, in which a human experimenter poured water from a bottle into the tube, to test whether results information alone (present in both experimental conditions) would also induce successes. Crucially, we controlled for social factors in both experimental conditions. Both types of demonstrations significantly increased successful spitting, with no differences between demonstration types. We also found that younger subjects were more likely to succeed than older ones. Our analysis showed that mere order effects could not explain our results. Conclusion The full demonstration condition (which potentially offers additional information to observers, in the form of actions), induced no more successes than the emulation condition. Hence, emulation learning could explain the success in both conditions. This finding has broad implications for the interpretation of chimpanzee traditions, for which emulation learning may perhaps suffice."

(Danwitz et al., 2025)

Observational learning of exploration-exploitation strategies in bandit tasks.

"Actions of others constitute an important source of information in everyday life (Bandura & Walters, 1977). When people adjust their

decisions based on observing actions performed by others, we speak about observational learning"

".One distinction of how social information is used is the level of representational exchange on which observational learning occurs (Wu et al., 2021). Imitation is a basic form of observational learning where the surface behavior is copied, while emulation involves understanding the reasons behind the behavior and replicating its structure (Byrne & Russon, 1998;Tomasello, 1996)."

(Lewis et al., 2020)

Learning and Animal Movement

"Social learning is an umbrella term for the learning pathway that includes transfer of skills, concepts, rules, and strategies that occur in social contexts and can affect individual behavior. Types of social learning include (i) social facilitation (increased probability of performing a behavior in the presence of a conspecific), (ii) local enhancement (an individual's interest in an object or location mediates interest/movement by others), and (iii) imitation (novel copying of a model behavior through observation that results in a reliably similar outcome) (Visalberghi and Fragaszy, 1990)."

(Lind et al., 2018)

Social learning through associative processes: a computational theory

"We conceptualize social learning as situations in which stimuli that arise from other individuals have an important role in learning"

".Our explorations show that, when guided by such predispositions, associative processes can give rise to a wide variety of social learning phenomena, such as stimulus and local enhancement, contextual imitation and simple production imitation, observational conditioning, and social and response facilitation. In addition, we clarify how associative mechanisms can result in transfer of information and behavior from experienced to naïve individuals."

(Kukofka et al., 2024)

The development of social attention in orangutans: comparing peering behaviour in wild and zoo-housed individuals

"However, to acquire more learning-intense skills such as tool use, high-fidelity forms of social learning, namely observational social learning (e.g., imitation or emulation) or interactions with other individuals (e.g., teaching) are needed to allow for reliable transmission of information (Carvajal and Schuppli 2022)"

".As such, attending to information provided by other individuals (i.e., social information) is a crucial element of social learning."

(Zhang et al., 2025)

Linking behaviour change techniques to mechanisms of action: Using the Theory and Techniques Tool alongside the Behaviour Change Intervention Ontology

"Social learning/imitation: A process by which thoughts, feelings and motivational states observed in others are internalised and replicated without the need for conscious awareness"

".Observational learning [GO:[0098597]: <Learning> that occurs through observing the behaviour of others"*

".• Imitative learning [GO:[0098596]: <Observational learning> in which new behaviours are acquired through imitation"

".• Vicarious learning [BCIO:[050794]: <Observational learning> through the feelings or actions of another person."

Core mechanisms of learning from others

Learning from others works through a few linked processes: people notice a model, remember what happened, can reproduce some version of it, and are more or less likely to do so depending on goals, rewards, and context. Social learning is therefore not just blind copying; it is shaped by attention, memory, motivation, expected outcomes, and cues about who is worth learning from. (20 sources)

A central idea in social learning theory is that people can acquire new behaviors without direct trial-and-error by observing models and the consequences of what happens to them. This includes imitation, modeling, and vicarious learning, where the learner updates behavior after seeing another person rewarded or punished rather than experiencing those outcomes firsthand. In Bandura's framework, much human learning comes from observation and instruction, and vicarious experience is also one of the main sources from which people build beliefs about their own efficacy and likely success. (Wells-Wilbon et al., 2001) (Bandura, 1977) (Cerbo et al., 2019) (Chaturvedi et al., 2024) (Mgaya, 2025)

This learning process is usually described as having four basic parts: attention, retention, reproduction, and

motivation. Learners must first notice the model, then encode and remember what was observed, later retrieve that representation to guide action, and finally have some reason or incentive to perform it. Because of these steps, observational learning is a cognitive process as well as a behavioral one: it depends on mental representation, recall, and self-regulation, not only on visible copying. (Brewer et al., 1998) (Hank et al., 2024) (Jiang et al., 2022) (Bandura, 1977) (Chen et al., 2024) (Sovitriana et al., 2025)

Whether a model is learned from depends in part on who that model is. Attention is stronger when models are seen as attractive, trustworthy, similar, competent, powerful, successful, or socially important, and people are often more likely to imitate those they admire, such as parents, teachers, peers, supervisors, or other role models. This is one reason why peer influence and role-model effects are often treated as special cases of social learning. (Brewer et al., 1998) (Tam et al., 2021) (Li et al., 2024) (Posner, 2021) (Khadka, 2024) (John et al., 2026)

A further mechanism is that people do not only copy acts; they also learn likely outcomes, emotional meanings, and social acceptability. Observation can transmit attitudes, emotional expressions, grateful or prosocial behavior, and expectations about what kinds of acts are rewarded, ignored, or punished. Because this can happen through simple exposure, some social learning is deliberate, but much of it is incidental or even unconscious. (Sciara et al., 2021) (Nosrati et al., 2023) (Hank et al., 2024) (Onaolapo et al., 2025)

The literature also stresses that observational learning is not identical to exact imitation. People may imitate specific movements, but they can also learn more abstractly by extracting information, rules, or strategies from what they observe and then adapting them to their own abilities and goals. In this sense, social learning often involves symbolic thought, anticipation of future consequences, and self-regulation rather than simple mimicry. (Mirabi et al., 2021) (Jiang et al., 2022) (Li et al., 2024)

Finally, social learning is often strategic. Learners can use cues about uncertainty, the success of a model, kinship, age, gender, expertise, or how common a behavior is when deciding what to adopt. A notable strategy in this work is success-biased learning: people preferentially copy behaviors linked to visible success or approval, which helps explain how skills, preferences, values, and norms can spread efficiently through groups. (Tam et al., 2021) (Onaolapo et al., 2025) (Joiner et al., 2017)

Evidence

(Wells-Wilbon et al., 2001)

Social Learning Theory and the Influence of Male Role Models on African American Children in PROJECT 2000

> *"(Brewer et al., 1998) carried imitation one step further by demonstrating how new behaviors can be acquired by simply watching a model. Observers are affected by the same punishment or reinforcement received by the model for their behavior. According to Bandura and Walter's (1963) theory of vicarious reinforcement, a child who sees a hard-working classmate praised by the teacher learns to try that behavior"*

> *".They saw the importance of observational learning: acquiring new skills, information, or altering old behaviors simply by watching other children and adults (Brewer & Wann, 1998;Couzijn, 1999;Honer, 1998;Shebilske, 1998). In fact, Bandura (1977) believed that much of learning comes from observational learning and instruction rather than from overt, trial-and-error behavior. Imitation of a model's behavior when the model is no longer present is a powerful learning skill."*

(Bandura, 1977)

Self-efficacy: toward a unifying theory of behavioral change.

> *"The present article presents an integrative theoretical framework to explain and to predict psychological changes achieved by different modes of treatment. This theory states that psychological procedures, whatever their form, alter the level and strength of self-efficacy. It is hypothesized that expectations of personal efficacy determine whether coping behavior will be initiated, how much effort will be expended, and how long it will be sustained in the face of obstacles and aversive experiences. Persistence in activities that are subjectively threatening but in fact relatively safe produces, through experiences of mastery, further enhancement of self-efficacy and corresponding reductions in defensive behavior. In the proposed model, expectations of personal efficacy are derived from four principal sources of information: performance accomplishments, vicarious experience, verbal persuasion, and physiological states. The more dependable the experiential sources, the greater are the changes in perceived selfefficacy. A number of factors are identified as influencing the cognitive processing of efficacy information arising from enactive, vicarious, exhortative,*

and emotive sources. The differential power of diverse therapeutic procedures is analyzed in terms of the postulated cognitive mechanism of operation. Findings are reported from microanalyses of enactive, vicarious, and emotive modes of treatment that support the hypothesized relationship between perceived self-efficacy and behavioral changes. Possible directions for further research are discussed."

(Cerbo et al., 2019)

The Social and Communication Skills Difficulties among Learners with Autism Spectrum Disorder

"The Social Learning Theory by Albert Bandura (Mc. Leod, 2012) affirms that behavior is learned from the environment, within a social context, through the process of learning by observation. Bandura (1976) posited that social skills cannot be taught in isolation. He postulated that people learn from one another by observation, imitation, and modeling. Teaching new behaviors; influencing the frequency of behaviors that were previously acquired; and increasing the frequency of manifesting similar behaviors are some of the effects of modeling. Observational learning, another term for social learning theory, takes place when an observer's behavior changes after viewing the behavior of a model. Social learning can take place within the classroom. Modeling of appropriate behavior and new skills could come from the teacher and the typically developing classmates."

(Chaturvedi et al., 2024)

The Impact of Peer Pressure on Emotional Competence and Resilience among Young Adults

"2. Social Learning Theory :posits that individuals learn through observation, imitation, and modeling of behaviors demonstrated by others in their social environment. According to this theory, learning is not solely based on direct reinforcement, but also occurs through vicarious reinforcement, where individuals observe the consequences of others' actions and adjust their behavior accordingly (Bandura, A. 1977). Social Learning Theory emphasizes the role of cognitive processes, such as attention, retention, reproduction, and motivation, in mediating observational learning"

".4. Normative Social Influence: According to this theory, which was put forth by psychologist Solomon Asch, people conform to group standards in order to win or lose favor with others. Peer pressure can lead people to imitate the actions of their peers in order to escape criticism or rejection. 5. Informational Social Influence: This theory proposes that people seek advice from others when faced with unclear or new circumstances."

(Mgaya, 2025)

Career Choices for Adult Students

"Social Learning Theory (SLT), originally developed by Albert Bandura in the 1960s, posits that learning occurs through observation, imitation, and modelling. It emphasizes the importance of social interaction and the environment in shaping behaviour. Unlike traditional behaviourism, which emphasizes direct reinforcement, SLT highlights that individuals can learn from observing the behaviours of others and the consequences of those behaviours. Bandura's ground-breaking work on the theory, particularly in his 1961 Bobo doll experiment, demonstrated that children would imitate aggressive behaviours observed in adults. He supported the idea that learning could occur through observation and not just direct reinforcement (Bandura, 1963)"

".A key component of SLT is the idea of observational learning, which is learning that happens by watching others and imitating their actions. According to Bandura (1969), for observational learning to occur, several factors must be present: attention, retention, reproduction, and motivation"

".SLT also incorporates the concept of vicarious reinforcement, where individuals learn by observing the consequences of others' behaviours. In his 1977 social learning theory, Albert Bandura (1977) contended that individuals can learn by observing others. They can also learn by modelling their behaviours. In so doing, they may not need to experience rewards or punishments directly. This goes simultaneously with emphasising the role of social interaction and cognitive processes in shaping behaviour. This aspect of the theory suggests that the social environment, including family, peers, and media, can significantly influences an individual's learning. For instance, if a child observes that a peer is praised for being polite, they are likely to imitate polite behaviours. Conversely, if they see a peer being punished for misbehaviour, they may avoid such retrogressive actions."

(Brewer et al., 1998)

Observational learning effectiveness as a function of model characteristics: Investigating the importance of social power

"Observational learning is an important component of human learning. According to Bandura (1965), observational learning is characterized by 4 stages: attention, retention, motor reproduction, and motivation. The first stage, attention, is a crucial subprocess that can be influenced by model characteristics. Characteristics such as attractive-ness, trustworthiness, similarity, and perceived competence have been shown to enhance a model's effectiveness. In this study we extended this research to social power. It was hypothesized that observational learning effectiveness would be greater in groups taught by a model with a base of social power than in a control group. A research question examined which base of social power (legitimate, expert, or referent) yielded the greatest effectiveness. Participants watched a tape of a model performing a puzzle task. The model was described as having one of the 3 bases of social power. A fourth group was taught by a model introduced without the mention of a base of social power. The results revealed that those in the power groups scored significantly higher on the variables of time elapsed to complete the puzzle, number of pieces correctly placed, and whether the participant finished or not. Implications for the findings of this study such as the

use of social power(s) in a teaching and managerial setting are discussed."

(Hank et al., 2024)

Do Peers Influence the Development of Individuals' Social Skills? The Potential of Cooperative Learning and Social Learning in Elementary Schools

"Within the framework of peer influence, there are evident parallels with the social learning paradigm (Bandura, 1971). The parallels lie in the preconditions for peer influence and social learning, which consist on the one hand in the salience of the peer behavior to be observed and on the other hand in the opportunity of imitating corresponding behavior. These characteristics and the empirical findings (e.g., (Busching et al., 2020) emphasize the role of social learning in developing prosocial behavior"

". In works that investigate peer influence, social learning (Bandura, 1971) has emerged as one of the underlying processes that explains its mechanisms (Brown et al., 2008). Bandura (1971) postulated that, while behaviors can sometimes be deliberately learned, they are often acquired inadvertently. Social learning processes depend on attentional processes, retention processes, motoric reproduction processes, and reinforcement and motivational processes (Bandura, 1971). Therefore, behaviors can only be learned if learners pay attention to a given behavior and are able to recollect it. Furthermore, learners must have the motoric skillset to reproduce an observed behavior. And finally, learning can be enhanced if models are reinforced for the respective behavior."

(Jiang et al., 2022)

Role of Program Curriculum in Building Social Skills and Sports Coaching in Academic and Career Development Under Sports Humanities and Sociology

"The social cognitive theory outlines the method of learning through observation and imitation. The theory refers to a psychological model of activity based on Bandura's research. It must have been created with such an emphasis on the acquisition of new behaviors in mind and it continues to emphasize that learning takes place in a social setting, with most of what is acquired coming through observation. Because it focuses on how mental cognitive aspects are engaged in learning, social cognitive theory is sometimes referred to as a bridge between classical learning theory, such as behaviorism and the mental process (Bandura, 1977). As per Bandura, most social learning is based on imitation, a process known as observational learning"

"Because learners must pay attention, develop and store mental representations of what they see, recover these representations from memory later, and use them to guide action, observational learning is considered a cognitive kind of learning (Sigelman and Rider, 2009). According to Bandura, observational learning may be summed up in two statements: most of the human learning is based on seeing and copying the actions of others or symbolic models such as fictitious characters in television shows and literature."

(Chen et al., 2024)

Weaving the Fabric of Social and Emotional Learning in the Context of Teaching: A Study in Hong Kong Kindergarten Classrooms

"(Bassett et al., 2020), positing that children learn by observing, modeling, and imitating the behaviors, dispositions, and emotional responses of others within their social contexts. However, drawing from behavioral and cognitive theories, Bandura emphasized that such "observational learning" could not be realized if cognitive processes were not involved in tandem."

(Sovitriana et al., 2025)

Model of strengthening student resilience through social learning theory Digital transformation in improving psychological well-being in Jakarta and West Java

"Social learning theory, introduced by Bandura (Bandura, 1977), emphasizes that learning does not only occur through direct experience but also through observation of others' behavior, imitation, and modeling. According to this framework, individuals observe the actions of others and the consequences of those actions, then form mental representations that become the basis for their future behavior. Bandura calls this process observational learning, which is influenced by four main components, namely: attention, retention, reproduction, and motivation [13]"

".SLT explains that learning does not only occur through direct experience or conditioning, as asserted in behaviorism, but also through observation of others' behavior and the consequences of that behavior."

(Tam et al., 2021)

Measuring behavioral social learning in a conservation context: Chilean fishing communities

"Behavioral social learning is typically considered to be a strategic process (Laland, 2004) in which individuals use cues about the learning context and content to select effective and adaptive behaviors to adopt (McElreath et al., 2008;(Rendell et al., 2011). For example, strategic social learning may utilize characteristics of the learner (e.g., learner uncertainty), characteristics of the role model (e.g., kinship, knowledge, success, age, gender), or the frequency of a behavior across multiple models (e.g., via conformity or copying rare behaviors) (Rendell et al., 2011)"

".So the most fundamental cue is the success behavior for the role model, and the most important social learning strategy may be

success-biased social learning (Baldini, 2012); the imitation of a given behavior based on the observed success of the person who practiced it"

".By allowing humans to transmit beliefs, values, norms, behaviors, and other cultural traits behavioral social learning is at the heart of human cultural evolution, the emergence of technology and the accumulation of social structure (Richerson & Boyd, 2005), and is considered a signature human adaptation (Boyd et al., 2011). The evidence suggests that many human behaviors are transmitted via social learning, including, for example, moral judgements (Bandura, 1969), mate preferences (Little, Jones, DeBruine, & Caldwell, 2011), consumer preferences (O'Hara & Stagl, 2002;Yang & Allenby, 2003), and even conservation behavior and attitudes (Horsley, 1977)."

(Li et al., 2024)

The Influence of Learning Team on User Creativity in Online Learning Community

"Observational learning, a major component of Social Learning Theory (Sharour et al., 2021), refers to individuals acquiring some new reactions or correcting some of their own behavioral reactions through observing others' behaviors and those subsequent negative or positive outcomes (Sharour et al., 2021). Observational learning is an efficient learning way to convey information (Bandura, 1986). Learning is not a purely personal behavior, but a cognitive process that can be realized by observing the behaviors of others and their consequences, including information extraction and decision making (Nasar et al., 2021)"

".By observing the abilities and achievements of others in the group and going through steps such as imitation, self-control, and self-regulation, learners can usually internalize the external learning skills of individuals into their own abilities, thereby improving their personal learning skills (Pålsson et al., 2020)"

".Under the influence of role models, the observers will produce the substitution and reinforcement experiences, which help them adjust their learning psychological state in time and enhance their learning motivation, so as to form correct behaviors or restrain the improper behaviors that have been formed, and finally achieve the effect of active and efficient learning (Posner, 2021)."

(Posner, 2021)

When learning how to lead, an exploratory look at role models

"PurposeThe purpose of this study is to identify who people indicate are their role models for learning how to lead and explore how demographic characteristics may affect these choices.Design/methodology/approachA global online survey, involving over 34,000 respondents, indicated, from a list of 14 possibilities, the role model category from whom they learned to lead. Respondents indicated their age, gender, ethnicity, nationality, educational level, hierarchical level and job function. Chi-square analysis was used to identify how these factors may have affected the choice of role models distribution.FindingsFamily member (parents, siblings and other family outside of the immediate family) was found to be the most important role model category when it came to learning how to lead. Ranked second was immediate supervisor/manager. The rank order in terms of frequency of role model choices was not substantially different across demographic characteristics, though there were statistically significant differences regarding the relative importance of the various role model categories by demographics.Research limitations/implicationsThe results offer plentiful opportunities for future scholars to delve more into both the nature and actions of role models, in keeping with social learning theory. Future scholars can investigate the nature of people's relationships with leadership role models, especially conceptualizing why and how various demographic factors affect how people learn to lead.Practical implicationsUnderstanding who people have as role models for what they have learned about leadership can provide important insights for those responsible for leadership development. Similarly, individuals who are in role model "positions" (e.g. parents, teachers, managers) can be more aware of how their behaviors have implications for how their audience learns what effective leadership looks like in action.Originality/valueThis study addressed a relatively unexplored area in the leadership literature, namely within what category of role model have people found to be most important in helping them learn to lead. The large and diverse sample, across a multitude of demographic characteristics, strengthens the generalizability of the findings."

(Khadka, 2024)

Social Learning Theory and the Development of Aggression

"Bandura challenged earlier behaviorist models, which focused primarily on stimulus-response mechanisms, by introducing the idea that learning occurs not only through direct experiences but also through observation of others"

".His Bobo Doll experiment demonstrated the role of observational learning in acquiring aggressive behaviors (Bandura, 1985). Children exposed to an adult model displaying aggression toward a Bobo doll were likely to imitate these actions, particularly when the model's behavior appeared socially rewarded"

".SLT's primary mechanism is observational learning, where individuals acquire new behaviors by observing others"

".Imitation, a subset of observational learning, refers to the replication of specific behaviors demonstrated by a model"

".children are more likely to imitate behaviors exhibited by parents, teachers, or peers they admire or consider role models (Bandura, 1986)."

(John et al., 2026)

Family Dynamics and Social Adjustment of Secondary School Students in Uyo and Nsit Ubium Local Government Areas of Akwa Ibom State

"The Social Learning Theory was propounded by Albert Bandura in 1977. The theory emphasizes that behavior is learned through observation, imitation, and interaction with others within the social environment. According to Bandura, individuals, especially children and adolescents, acquire new behaviors by observing significant others such as parents, peers, and teachers and by modeling their actions."

(Sciara et al., 2021)

Gratitude and Social Media: A Pilot Experiment on the Benefits of Exposure to Others' Grateful Interactions on Facebook

"According to the theory of social learning (Bandura, 1968), observing other's interactions could make people apprehend behaviors of any sort, including grateful behaviors. As originally described by the theory, observational learning is the ability to learn new responses as a result of observing behavioral models (Browder et al., 1986)(Bandura, , 1968)). Importantly, as observation and imitation are spontaneous phenomena, simple exposure to others' attitudes and behaviors can cause the natural acquisition of such attitudes and behaviors, also when learning is not planned (Bandura, 1971; see also (Browder et al., 1986). Through observation, people can indeed learn attitudes, feelings' expressions, and specific emotional behaviors (Kanekar, 1973)(Kanekar, 1976)."

(Nosrati et al., 2023)

Partner choices in the age of social media: are there significant relationships between following influencers on Instagram and partner choice criteria?

"The theory, also known by other names such as the social learning theory, explores how individuals acquire behaviors in social settings through processes of observation, imitation, and modeling. This form of social learning, rooted in observation and imitation, occurs unconsciously in many individuals who possess the capacity for attention, interest, as well as the ability to mimic and emulate behaviors. It brings about its own positive or negative consequences (Kadivar, 2013)"

".One of the prevalent methods of this type of learning is vicarious learning, also referred to as modeling, whereby individuals acquire knowledge by observing others' behavior and its subsequent consequences. The emphasis on observational learning constitutes a distinctive feature of Bandura's theory."

(Onaolapo et al., 2025)

Exploration of Social Cognitive Learning Theory: An Expedition to re-enact Gender-based Violence Prevention Strategies in Nigerian Secondary Schools

"The process through which individuals acquire new behaviours, attitudes, and beliefs is known as social modelling, sometimes known as observational learning or social learning. 24"

"From early childhood, individuals are constantly exposed to various social models, including parents, peers, teachers, and media figures. These models exhibit behaviours that are observed and internalized by individuals, influencing their actions and beliefs. (Schunk et al., 1997) Social modelling occurs through the observation of others' behaviours, the consequences that follow, and the interpretation of those behaviours"

".Once the behaviour is stored in memory, individuals can reproduce or imitate it. 28"

"People are more prone to copy actions that are linked to successful results, prizes, or social acceptance. (Malek et al., 2020) The model's attractiveness or reputation, the behaviour's perceived worth, and the predicted results can all have an impact on why people choose to emulate them. Reinforcement also plays a role in social modelling. Positive reinforcement, such as praise or rewards, strengthens the likelihood of imitating the behaviour. 30"

(Mirabi et al., 2021)

The Impact of Celebrity Endorsement of Sporting Goods on Consumer Purchasing Behavior

"Observational learning was developed by Albert Bandura, yet he makes a distinction between observational learning and mere emulation of behavioral pattern. Observational learning may include imitation or not. Three major ideas emanate from observational learning (Hergenhan and Olson, 2005). A) Observational learning theorists regard people as symbolic beings that are able to predict the possible outcomes of their behavior. People anticipate the future and modify their behavior accordingly. B) People have the ability to regulate their own behavior, and through self-regulatory, self-critical or self-appreciative processes, they internally punish or reward themselves. C) By observing the actions of others and relevant consequences, people can achieve learning. Social learning theorists in particular have underlined the importance of the models in the transfer of information through observational learning (Shahbazi, 2012)."

(Joiner et al., 2017)

Social learning through prediction error in the brain

> *"Imitation in human children is most famously exemplified in observational learning or, more broadly, social learning studies. 12 ocial learning occurs when the learner watches another agent act. Notably, without any practice or direct primary reinforcement, the learner can perform the previously observed behavior. This suggests that the learner is able to acquire new knowledge or skills from watching other's experienced outcomes, possibly through vicarious reinforcement. (Bandura et al., 1963)"*

> *"n humans, observational learning may be at the core of establishing social and cultural norms. 12 In Bandura's classic study (Bandura et al., 1963) on behavioral modeling, children that saw an adult model aggressive behavior toward a large doll later performed the same aggressive behaviors when given the opportunity to interact with the same doll."*

Peer influence, conformity, and social norms

Peer influence is one of the main ways social learning works in everyday life. People do not just copy peers' actions; they also learn what is normal, rewarded, approved, or expected in a group. (9 sources)

Peer influence can be understood as social learning that happens in real groups: classmates, friends, siblings, teammates, and other close associates provide models for behavior, attitudes, and expectations. In this view, peers matter not only because they are present, but because repeated association exposes people to definitions of what is acceptable, chances to imitate, and patterns of reward and punishment that make some behaviors more likely to continue. This logic appears in both Bandura-style social learning and Akers' version, which emphasizes peer association, definitions, imitation, and reinforcement. (Mus et al., 2021) (Muhia, 2021)

A key point is that peers transmit both behavior and social cognition. By watching what others do, learners can acquire scripts for how to act, beliefs about what kinds of behavior are appropriate, and expectations about how others will respond. This helps explain why peer groups can spread both prosocial and harmful conduct: observational learning can support helping, cooperation, and positive intergroup contact, but it can also support aggression, substance use, or other risky behavior when those patterns are visible and tolerated. (Busching et al., 2020) (Busching et al._1, 2020) (Huesmann, 2017) (Muhia, 2021)

Conformity is one route by which this happens. Under normative social influence, people adjust to group standards to gain approval or avoid disapproval, criticism, or exclusion. Under informational social influence, people look to others when a situation is new, uncertain, or ambiguous, using others' behavior as evidence about what is correct or effective. In practice, many peer effects mix both processes: people may copy because others seem right, because others seem popular, or because fitting in has social value of its own. (Chaturvedi et al., 2024) (Asif et al., 2025)

Social norms are especially important because they turn scattered observations into shared expectations. When many group members act in the same way, that behavior becomes more visible and more salient as a local norm, which can then guide further adoption through observational learning. Research on adolescent classrooms suggests that norms can differ a lot across groups: in some classrooms, aggression is tied to popularity, while in others prosocial behavior is more supported. Group composition matters here, because socially dominant aggressive students can help create aggressive popularity norms, while socially dominant prosocial students can weaken them. (Busching et al._1, 2020) (Laninga-Wijnen et al., 2019)

The same logic applies to positive behavior. If adolescents see peers endorsing friendly contact across group lines, they are more likely to act prosocially toward outgroup members; if they are surrounded by helpful peers, reciprocity norms can become more salient and helping can spread. Similarity also matters: people often learn more from models they see as like themselves, which is one reason age-homogeneous peer settings such as classrooms can be strong sites of norm transmission. (Busching et al., 2020) (Busching et al._1, 2020)

Peer influence is therefore not just simple imitation. It is tied to identity, status, belonging, and group membership. Especially in adolescence, peer groups can become major reference points for study habits, engagement, substance use, cooperation, and everyday conduct, because people often define themselves partly through the groups they belong to and adjust behavior to match group-linked norms and expectations. (Saha, 2025) (Asif et al., 2025)

Overall, conformity and peer influence are best seen as social learning filtered through group life. People observe others, infer what is normal and rewarded, and then adapt behavior in ways that can stabilize customs, spread norms, and reproduce both helpful and harmful patterns over time. (Mus et al., 2021) (Busching et al., 2020) (Huesmann, 2017)

Evidence

(Mus et al., 2021)

Evaluating the Relationships Between Demographic, Level of Drug Use and Self Esteem Among Female Students in Kaduna, Nigeria

"The social learning theory postulated by Bandura (1977) holds that people learn by observing others. The ability to learn is central to individual personality, as behavior observed can change the way a person thinks; also, the behavior of individuals may be influenced by environmental factors (Bandura, 1977)"

".Social learning theorists contend that people can learn through observation and store information cognitively to act in the future and that their learning may not necessarily be shown in their performance (Akers, 1998;Bandura, 1986). The version of social learning propounded by Akers (1998) involves the components peer association, definitions, imitation, and reinforcement. Peer association involves the exposure to behavior and attitudes through one's association with others, definitions refers to individuals' attitudes toward behavior, imitation occurs when individuals model their behavior after the performance of others, and reinforcement is the use of rewards to continue any behavior (Akers, 1998). Researchers have found peer association appropriate for the study of drug use and social learning, especially because findings indicate that involvement with peers who approve drug use increases the chances of using drugs (Akers, 1998). People may learn from belief systems (i.e., the behaviors of individuals learned from from role models such as family members, close acquaintances, friends, or peer groups) and as a result of external influences in the environment may change their behavior (Bandura, 1986)."

(Muhia, 2021)

Impact of Peer Influence on Substance Abuse among Students in Public Day Secondary Schools in Thika Sub-County, Kiambu County

"Social learning theory (Bandura, 1977) suggests continuous and reciprocal interaction between the individuals' cognition and behavior exist within the ecological environment where human behavior is developed. According to Bandura (1977), human behavior is not inborn. Rather it is learned through our socialization process.

Individual observational learning is acquired by attention to and retention of activities. Such activities are determined by interpersonal interactions and behaviors of people with whom individuals regularly associate. Modeling is the stage where individuals have strong motivation to deliberately shape their behaviors in accordance with symbolic behaviors of others.

According to the SLT, adolescents are vulnerable to alcohol and drug use through regular observation and interaction with family and peers who use substances. Regular observation and interaction enables adolescents attend to, memorize, and want to imitate substance use behavior.

Bandura and Walters emphasize that children learn through observing the behavior of others and imitating them, a process referred to as modeling. Modeling then becomes a socialization process through which habitual response patterns develop. As children grow, they imitate different models from their social environment. Parents, siblings and extended family members are some of the most significant individuals in adolescents' lives. Actions are acquired primarily through observational learning rather than operant conditioning or classical conditioning. Through observation and internalization of other people's experiences, people learn good or bad behaviors.

According to this theory, people observe their social world, extract information from it, generate expectations and then make choices that maximize environmental rewards, maintain an inner feeling of competence while at the same time avoiding negative outcomes."

(Busching et al., 2020)

With a Little Help from Their Peers: The Impact of Classmates on Adolescents' Development of Prosocial Behavior

"The psychological processes underlying the influence of peer groups on social behavior in general and prosocial as well as aggressive behavior in particular may be explained by social learning theory (Bandura 1977). This theory highlights observational learning as a key mechanism by which individuals acquire both positive and negative forms of social behavior (Hoorn et al., 2016)). Observational learning is not limited to the acquisition of patterns of behavior but also contributes to the development of social cognitions, such as cognitive scripts and normative beliefs about certain types of behavior (Huesmann, 2017)"

".In a study on intergroup contact between Catholics and Protestants in Northern Ireland, adolescents who perceived their peers to hold positive views about intergroup contact, defining a pro-outgroup norm, were more likely to engage in prosocial behavior toward

outgroup members (McKeown et al., 2018)"

".This norm should be more salient if many adolescents show prosocial behavior and should facilitate the adoption of prosocial behavior through the process of observational learning. Social learning theory posits that similar models are more likely to serve as a source of observational learning than dissimilar models, so age-homogeneous groups, such as classroom communities, should facilitate observational learning."

(Busching et al._1, 2020)

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In the case of prosocial behavior, the norm of reciprocity plays a crucial role. The norm of reciprocity refers to the belief that individuals should help others if these had helped them (Penner et al. 2005). Thus, being surrounded by prosocial peers, from whom individuals receive help, should increase their willingness to show prosocial behavior towards these others. This norm should be more salient if many adolescents show prosocial behavior and should facilitate the adoption of prosocial behavior through the process of observational learning. Social learning theory posits that similar models are more likely to serve as a source of observational learning than dissimilar models, so age-homogeneous groups, such as classroom communities, should facilitate observational learning."

(Huesmann, 2017)

An integrative theoretical understanding of aggression: a brief exposition

"Like other social behaviors, aggressive behavior is always a product of predisposing personal factors and precipitating situational factors. The predisposing factors exert their influence by creating encoded social cognitions including schemas about the world, scripts for social behavior, and normative beliefs about what is appropriate. These social cognitions interact with situational primes to determine behavior. These social cognitions are acquired primarily through observational learning; so youth who are repeatedly exposed to violence will acquire social cognitions promoting aggression that last into adulthood. Thus, violence can be viewed as a contagious disease which can be caught simply through its observation."

(Chaturvedi et al., 2024)

The Impact of Peer Pressure on Emotional Competence and Resilience among Young Adults

"2. Social Learning Theory :posits that individuals learn through observation, imitation, and modeling of behaviors demonstrated by others in their social environment. According to this theory, learning is not solely based on direct reinforcement, but also occurs through vicarious reinforcement, where individuals observe the consequences of others' actions and adjust their behavior accordingly (Bandura, A. 1977). Social Learning Theory emphasizes the role of cognitive processes, such as attention, retention, reproduction, and motivation, in mediating observational learning"

".4. Normative Social Influence: According to this theory, which was put forth by psychologist Solomon Asch, people conform to group standards in order to win or lose favor with others. Peer pressure can lead people to imitate the actions of their peers in order to escape criticism or rejection. 5. Informational Social Influence: This theory proposes that people seek advice from others when faced with unclear or new circumstances."

(Asif et al., 2025)

Honor killing and the cycle of social influence: A study of the Pakistani bride through Albert Bandura's social learning theory

"This theory is based on three main concepts i.e; modeling, reinforcement, and observational learning. The process by which individuals observe and imitate the behaviors of others is called "Modeling" in Social Learning Theory. Bandura brought attentions to the fact that the actions of role models, people who are respected or enjoy positions of authority in the particular society, have a deep influence on shaping behaviors. This means that individuals are likely to mimic these frequently observed behaviors, especially if these behaviors support the societal customs or expectations (1977)"

".Additionally, social influences-such as community norms, peer pressure, and cultural values-act as mechanisms that perpetuate specific behaviors within societies. Through these social structures, behaviors that align with cultural expectations are consistently reinforced, shaping collective norms"

".Bandura (Ibid) noted that observational learning occurs when an individual pays attention to the behavior, retains the details, reproduces the behavior, and is motivated to do so. The motivation to imitate behaviors is often influenced by the anticipated rewards or punishments and the desire to align with cultural norms or gain social approval. Thus, Social Learning Theory emphasizes the interplay between individual cognition and the social environment in the learning process. Social Learning Theory also considers how cultural and social contexts impact learning and the perpetuation of behavior. Behaviors become normalized and sustained within a community when they are widely modeled and reinforced, creating a cycle of cultural transmission."

(Laninga-Wijnen et al., 2019)

Who Sets the Aggressive Popularity Norm in Classrooms? It's the Number and Strength of Aggressive, Prosocial, and Bi-Strategic Adolescents

"Previous work has shown that during adolescence, classrooms vary greatly in the extent to which aggression is rewarded with popularity (the 'popularity norm'). Aggressive popularity norms may promote the proliferation of aggression and negatively affect the classroom climate. It is, however, unknown how these norms emerge in the first place. This longitudinal study therefore investigated whether aggressive popularity norms can be predicted by the classroom composition of students. We examined whether the prevalence of six student types - socially and non-socially dominant prosocial, aggressive, and bi-strategic adolescents (adolescents who are both highly prosocial and aggressive) - contributed to the norm by establishing a popularity hierarchy: strong classroom asymmetries in popularity. We collected peer-nominated data at three secondary schools in the Netherlands (SNARE-study; Nstudents = 2843; Nclassrooms = 120; 51.4% girls; Mage = 13.2). Classroom-level regression analyses suggest that the classroom percentage of socially dominant aggressive and bi-strategic students predicted higher aggressive popularity norms, both directly and by enhancing the classrooms' popularity hierarchy. Instead, the presence of non-socially dominant aggressive students and socially dominant prosocial students contributed to lower aggressive popularity norms. Socially dominant prosocial students also buffered against the role of socially dominant aggressive adolescents in the aggressive popularity norm (moderation), but not against bi-strategic adolescents' role. Our findings indicate that interventions aimed at reducing aggressive popularity norms should first and foremost take the composition of classrooms at the start of the school year into account; and should not only encourage prosocial behavior, but also actively discourage aggression."

(Saha, 2025)

Peer Influence, Identity, and Learning: The Sociology of Educational Affinity among Adolescents

"According to Bandura's social learning theory, "people learn from one another via observation, imitation, and modeling" (Bandura, 1977, p. 22). Peers act as role models for study habits, academic engagement, and cooperative problemsolving in educational settings, making social learning an essential tool for influencing teenagers' educational paths. The development of identity and group identification is intimately related to the sociological significance of peer influence. According to (Tajfel et al., 2004), "people define themselves in terms of the groups to which they belong, and this membership shapes their norms, attitudes, and behaviors" (p. 16). Peer groups frequently serve as the main source of reference for social and academic habits during adolescence, impacting students' drive to learn, involvement in group projects, and school engagement. As teenagers try to fit in with classmates who have similar academic interests, educational affinity develops, strengthening common learning strategies and creating a feeling of community."

Models, contexts, and transmission pathways

Social learning depends not just on what is observed, but on where, with whom, and through what relationship it is observed. People learn more from some models than others, and they also shift between using their own experience and social information depending on trust, shared attention, and the stability of others' intentions. (7 sources)

Who serves as a model matters, but the setting in which the model is observed matters too. A common finding across social learning work is that people are more likely to learn from models they see as similar, important, skilled, or authoritative. Yet learning is not only about identifying with the model. It can also be strengthened by the immediate interpersonal context, especially when attention is shared with an in-group other while the behavior is being observed. In experiments, imitation was especially likely under this condition of simultaneous observation with a similar other, suggesting that shared in-group attention can make modeled behavior more socially learnable. (Shteynberg et al., 2013) (Haule et al., 2024)

This helps connect social learning to transmission pathways. Information can pass vertically from parents, obliquely from older non-parents such as teachers or mentors, and horizontally among peers, but these pathways do not all work in the same way. Parent and teacher pathways often carry authority and instruction, while peer pathways often carry similarity, joint attention, and repeated exposure. In humans, these pathways support more than simple copying: early cultural learning includes conformity for affiliation with the group, active instruction by adults, and the reliable passing on of group-specific ways of seeing and doing things.

These features help explain why human social learning can accumulate complex knowledge across generations. (Schie et al., 2023) (Tomasello, 2016)

Another important point is that people do not treat all social information as equal. They can adjust how much they rely on others based on source qualities such as trustworthiness, intentions, and past interaction history. Positive or negative social experiences can leave people more or less open to learning from others, which means social learning is partly shaped by relational context, not just by the current task. More recent work also points to increasingly refined forms of social and cognitive selection in observation and imitation, with clear implications for teaching and training. (Schie et al., 2023) (Diaconescu et al., 2014) (Shang et al., 2025)

Computational and neuroscience work adds a useful model of how this happens. Social information can be learned using processes similar to those used in reward-based learning, rather than through a wholly separate system. People appear to track how accurate an adviser is, infer whether that person's intentions are stable or changing, and then combine this estimate with nonsocial evidence when making choices. In other words, learners can update on advice much as they update on rewards, while also monitoring whether the social source is reliable enough to keep using. (Behrens et al., 2008) (Diaconescu et al., 2014)

Taken together, this research shows that social learning is filtered through model choice, relationship history, group context, and channel of transmission. People learn not only by seeing an action, but by judging who is acting, whether others are attending too, how trustworthy the source seems, and whether the social world around them makes that information worth using. (Shteynberg et al., 2013) (Schie et al., 2023) (Behrens et al., 2008)

Evidence

(Shteynberg et al., 2013)

The Power of Shared Experience

> *"Across disciplines, social learning research has been unified by the principle that people learn new behaviors to the extent that they identify with the actor modeling them. We propose that this conceptualization may overlook the power of the interpersonal situation in which the modeled behavior is observed. Specifically, we predict that contexts characterized by shared in-group attention are particularly conducive to social learning"*

> *".Across both studies, results reveal that imitation is especially likely among individuals placed in the specific context of simultaneous observation with a similar other. These findings suggest that shared in-group attention is uniquely adaptive for social learning."*

(Haule et al., 2024)

The Contribution of Collaboration among the Parents, Teachers and Community on Public Secondary Schools Students'Academic Performance in Kibaha District

> *"people learn behaviors, values, and attitudes through observation, imitation, and modeling rather than through direct experience alone. This theory emphasizes the role of social interactions and the environment in shaping individual behavior. Bandura's seminal work demonstrates that learning occurs not only through personal experience but also by observing others, particularly those who are perceived as role models or authority figures (Bandura, 1977)."*

(Schie et al., 2023)

A boost in self-esteem after positive social evaluation predicts social and non-social learning

> *"social learning is evolutionarily adaptive, as it allows us to accumulate large amounts of complex knowledge in an efficient way across generations (Boyd et al., 2011)(Schaik et al., 2011)(Tomasello, 2016). Indeed, observational learning, complex imitation, understanding of social cues and theory of mind play an important role in the human acquisition of cognitive skills and knowledge [5]"*

> *".it may be relevant to adapt the tendency toward incorporating social information in decisions depending on the qualities of the source providing the social information (e.g. trustworthiness, intentions) (Behrens et al., 2008)(Diaconescu et al., 2014). Previous interaction experiences can foster the propensity to flexibly shift between relying on one's own perception and using social information. Importantly, the type of social interactions people have had, now or in the past (e.g. positive, negative), may put us in a state that is more or less open to learning from others (Fonagy et al., 2014)."*

(Tomasello, 2016)

The ontogeny of cultural learning.

> *"All primates engage in one or another form of social learning. Humans engage in cultural learning. From very early in ontogeny human infants and young children do not just learn useful things from others, they conform to others in order to affiliate with them and to identify with the cultural group. The cultural group normatively expects such conformity, and adults actively instruct children so as to ensure it. Young children learn from this instruction how the world is viewed and how it works in their culture. These special forms of cultural learning enable powerful and species-unique processes of cumulative cultural evolution."*

(Diaconescu et al., 2014)

Inferring on the Intentions of Others by Hierarchical Bayesian Learning

> *"Inferring on others' (potentially time-varying) intentions is a fundamental problem during many social transactions. To investigate the underlying mechanisms, we applied computational modeling to behavioral data from an economic game in which 16 pairs of volunteers (randomly assigned to "player" or "adviser" roles) interacted. The player performed a probabilistic reinforcement learning task, receiving information about a binary lottery from a visual pie chart. The adviser, who received more predictive information, issued an additional recommendation. Critically, the game was structured such that the adviser's incentives to provide helpful or misleading information varied in time. Using a meta-Bayesian modeling framework, we found that the players' behavior was best explained by the deployment of hierarchical learning: they inferred upon the volatility of the advisers' intentions in order to optimize their predictions about the validity of their advice. Beyond learning, volatility estimates also affected the trial-by-trial variability of decisions: participants were more likely to rely on their estimates of advice accuracy for making choices when they believed that the adviser's intentions were presently stable. Finally, our model of the players' inference predicted the players' interpersonal reactivity index (IRI) scores, explicit ratings of the advisers' helpfulness and the advisers' self-reports on their chosen strategy. Overall, our results suggest that humans (i) employ hierarchical generative models to infer on the changing intentions of others, (ii) use volatility estimates to inform decision-making in social interactions, and (iii) integrate estimates of advice accuracy with non-social sources of information. The Bayesian framework presented here can quantify individual differences in these mechanisms from simple behavioral readouts and may prove useful in future clinical studies of maladaptive social cognition."*

(Shang et al., 2025)

Reassessing the two-stage theory of social learning development: a discussion

> *"We conclude by highlighting the increasing sophistication of cognitive and social selection processes in observation, imitation, and learning, alongside the implications for educational practices."*

(Behrens et al., 2008)

Associative learning of social value

> *"Our decisions are guided by information learnt from our environment. This information may come via personal experiences of reward, but also from the behaviour of social partners. Social learning is widely held to be distinct from other forms of learning in its mechanism and neural implementation; it is often assumed to compete with simpler mechanisms, such as reward-based associative learning, to drive behaviour. Recently, neural signals have been observed during social exchange reminiscent of signals seen in studies of associative learning. Here we demonstrate that social information may be acquired using the same associative processes assumed to underlie reward-based learning. We find that key computational variables for learning in the social and reward domains are processed in a similar fashion, but in parallel neural processing streams. Two neighbouring divisions of the anterior cingulate cortex were central to learning about social and reward-based information, and for determining the extent to which each source of information guides behaviour. When making a decision, however, the information learnt using these parallel streams was combined within ventromedial prefrontal cortex. These findings suggest that human social valuation can be realized by means of the same associative processes previously established for learning other, simpler, features of the environment."*

Functions, domains, and consequences of social learning

Social learning helps people avoid costly trial and error, solve problems together, and pass knowledge across generations. It also shapes moral values, emotional regulation, socialization, and everyday adaptation, so its effects can be both highly useful and far-reaching. (3 sources)

One major function of social learning is efficiency. By watching others, taking advice, or copying tested behavior, people can avoid some of the pain, risk, and wasted effort that come with learning everything alone. This matters for survival and goal-directed action because learners can benefit from others' mistakes and successes without having to experience every consequence firsthand. Social learning is therefore not just convenient; it can let groups solve problems that are hard for isolated individuals, including cooperation in social dilemmas and the buildup of knowledge across generations. That is one reason notable work in this

area argues that humans likely evolved mechanisms that support strong social learning capacities. (Biele et al., 2011) (Peleg, 2025)

A second broad function is cultural transmission. Explicit advice, imitation, and other social learning processes help move skills, practices, and know-how from one person to another, which supports cumulative culture rather than constant rediscovery. In this sense, social learning is one of the main ways groups preserve useful information over time and make it available to new members. (Biele et al., 2011)

Social learning also operates in moral and emotional domains, not only in practical skill learning. People can acquire moral values, ethical principles, and ways of managing emotion by observing how others behave and how others respond to that behavior. Through family, peers, and media, learners pick up models of what counts as right, wrong, admirable, shameful, caring, or acceptable, and these models can shape moral reasoning, decision making, and emotional intelligence. (Nyamori, 2024)

Relatedly, one consequence of social learning is socialization: it helps children grow into adults who can function in groups, support themselves, avoid some forms of deviant behavior, and build close social ties. Because children depend heavily on important others, repeated interaction with parents and other significant figures can have lasting effects on later social behavior across settings. (Peleg, 2025)

These consequences are not always positive. The same mechanisms that spread cooperation, moral conduct, and useful skills can also spread harmful habits, poor models, and maladaptive norms if those are what learners see rewarded or treated as normal. So the effects of social learning depend less on the mechanism itself than on the social environment supplying the examples, feedback, and reinforcement. (Nyamori, 2024) (Peleg, 2025)

Overall, social learning matters because it does many jobs at once: it reduces the costs of learning, supports culture, helps coordinate social life, and shapes moral, emotional, and practical development. Its consequences reach from immediate behavior change to long-term patterns in families, groups, and whole societies. (Biele et al., 2011) (Nyamori, 2024) (Peleg, 2025)

Evidence

(Biele et al., 2011)

The Neural Basis of Following Advice

> *"Learning by following explicit advice is fundamental for human cultural evolution, yet the neurobiology of adaptive social learning is largely unknown"*
>
> *". Likewise, it has been proposed that imitation-another form of social learning-has the quality of a secondary reinforcer for children, who frequently experience that imitation leads to positive outcomes [43]. Mathematical analysis shows that the propensity for social learning can evolve on the population level in the environmental conditions that characterized the era of human evolutionary adaptation [2,4]. Moreover, social learning can solve problems that individual learning cannot, such as cooperation in social dilemmas or the accumulation of knowledge across generations [2,6,7,44]. Therefore, it seems plausible that humans have evolved mechanisms for social learning [5]45]."*

(Peleg, 2025)

SIBLING RELATIONSHIPS – A THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK AND THEIR IMPACT ON INDIVIDUAL DEVELOPMENT

> *"The Social Learning Theory, proposed by psychologist Albert Bandura in the 1960s, prompted a revolution in terms of understanding human behavior, by emphasizing the role of observational learning, imitation, and modeling in affecting individuals' actions, attitudes, and beliefs. This theory suggests that individual learning is not limited to direct experiences, but also occurs through observing others and the consequences of their actions. Through this process, individuals acquire new behaviors and skills and develop cognitive structures influencing their future actions"*
>
> *".The above-described ability is considered to pertain to survival. It facilitates learning from others' mistakes, guides individuals for future goal-oriented behaviors, and prevents unnecessary pain (Bandura, 1977). It is also noteworthy that socialization is another means of social learning. This process aims at facilitating children's growth into adults who are capable of adaptive functioning, namely, avoiding deviant behaviors, being able to support themselves and their families, and forming and maintaining close connections with others (Maccoby & Martin, 1983) . Social Learning Theory is based upon the following core principles: •*

Observational Learning; • Imitation and Modelling; • Reinforcement and Punishment; • Self-efficacy. Furthermore, Bandura (1977) refers to socialization as a process of identification and assimilation, which is related to the child's dependence on relationships with other significant figures. The key assumption states that interaction with other significant figures affects the child's social behavior within other structures, as well as later in life (Maccoby & Martin, 1983)."

(Nyamori, 2024)

Exploring the Relationship between Moral Decision-Making and Emotional Intelligence

"Social Learning Theory, originally proposed by Albert Bandura in the 1960s, posits that individuals learn by observing the behavior of others and the consequences of those behaviors. This theory emphasizes the role of modeling, imitation, and reinforcement in shaping human behavior (Bandura, 1977). In the context of exploring the relationship between moral decision-making and emotional intelligence, Social Learning Theory provides valuable insights into how individuals acquire moral values, ethical principles, and emotional regulation strategies through social interactions and observational learning. According to this theory, individuals develop their moral reasoning and decision-making skills by observing the ethical behavior of others and the emotional responses elicited by such behavior. Additionally, Social Learning Theory highlights the importance of environmental influences, such as family, peers, and media, in shaping individuals' moral development and emotional intelligence. By grounding research in Social Learning Theory, researchers can examine the impact of social modeling, vicarious learning experiences, and reinforcement mechanisms on the development of moral decision-making abilities and emotional intelligence, thereby offering a comprehensive understanding of the interplay between social factors, cognition, and behavior in ethical decisionmaking processes."